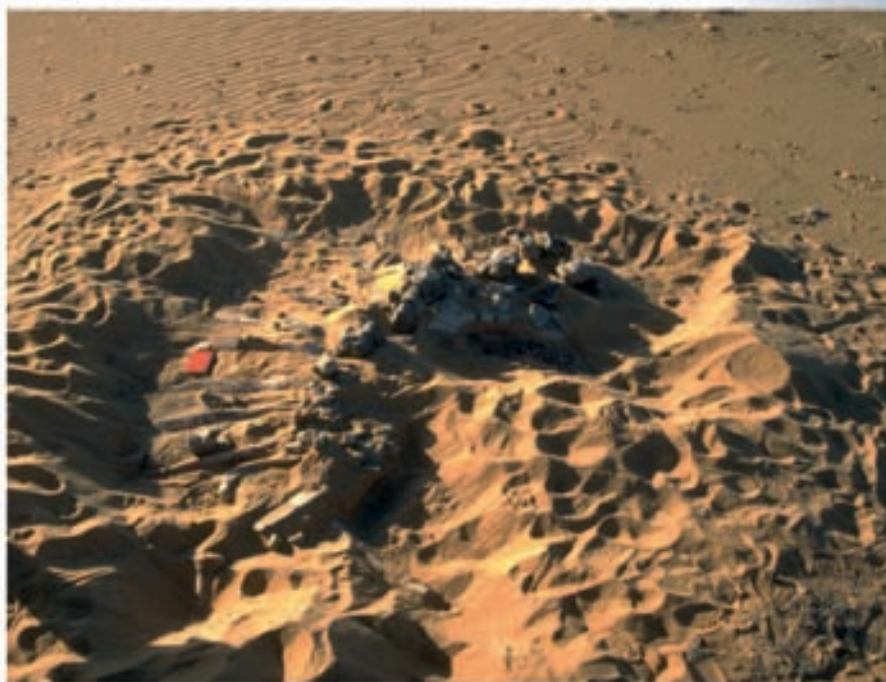


Fossil hunting

You may have seen a fossil hunt on television, or you may have visited a fossil site. Perhaps you have been lucky enough to find your own fossil. What happens on an organized fossil dig?

A fossil hunter's toolbox

Scientists who study fossils are called paleontologists. Paleontologists use basic digging tools to remove fossils from the ground, such as hammers, chisels, and trowels. Brushes help sweep away dust.



IT WAS FOUND THERE!

Every dinosaur dig is different. Some fossils are found embedded in solid rock that needs to be chipped away bit by bit. Others fall out of soft, crumbly cliffs and can be very fragile, falling apart easily. The *Ouranosaurus* (a plant-eating dinosaur) above was found buried in the desert sand and was easy to dig out by hand.



UNCOVERING FOSSILS

Paleontologists classify the dinosaur fossils they uncover in one of four ways.

■ **Articulated skeleton.** This is a skeleton that is still joined together. It may be complete, but pieces are usually missing.

■ **Associated skeleton.** This means the bones have broken up and spread out, but they can be identified as belonging to the same dinosaur.

■ **Isolated bone.** This is a bone that has been separated from its skeleton, and fossilized alone. It may be a leg bone such as a femur (thigh bone), which is a large fossil.

■ **Float.** These are scraps of fossilized bone—the fossil has shattered, and the scraps are usually too small to be useful.